

Isotonic contraction Muscle engagement where the muscle changes length; can either be eccentric or concentric.

Kinesiology Study of body movement.

Kumbhaka Pranayama practice of breath retention.

Kyphosis Convex curves of the spine, found naturally in the thoracic spine and sacrum; the term can also describe an excessive amount of this convex curve, as in a dowager's hump.

Ligament Connects bone to bone; made of dense regular connective tissue proper, which has parallel collagen fibers.

Lordosis Concave curves of the spine, found naturally in the lumbar and cervical spine; the term can also describe an excessive amount of this concave curve.

Lumbar spine Five vertebrae of the low back.

Lymph Fluid filled with white blood cells to fight invaders; collected from interstitial fluid, it drains back into the heart after being filtered in lymph nodes.

Meditation Concentration or mental focus exercise; includes mindfulness, mantra, loving-kindness, transcendental meditation (TM), and others; Dhyana, in Sanskrit.

Meta-analysis Systematic assessment of previous research in a specific area to derive broad conclusions; the gold standard of review articles.

Mindfulness Paying attention on purpose to the present moment, without judgment (as defined by researcher Jon Kabat Zinn, PhD).

Muscle tissue Contractile tissue; the three types are skeletal, smooth, and cardiac muscle.

Nadis According to Indian medicine and Hindu philosophy, these are channels for prana to flow.

Nerve Bundle of axons of neurons in the peripheral nervous system; conductive tissue that acts like wires through the body, carrying signals to and from the central nervous system. Includes cranial nerves and spinal nerves; a bundle of axons in the central nervous system is called a tract.

Nervous tissue Conductive tissue made of neurons and helper cells.

Neuron Nerve cell; carries electrical signals.

Neuroplasticity Ability of the brain to create neural connections.

Neutral spine Position of optimal load distribution for the spine; maintains the natural curves of the cervical (lordosis), thoracic (kyphosis), and lumbar (lordosis) segments of the spine.

Neutral pelvis Position of the pelvis that best supports the inward curve of the lumbar spine. No excessive anterior or posterior pelvic tilt; hip points are in line with each other; minimized stress on ligaments, muscles, and other tissues.

Osteoporosis Condition where bones become weak and brittle, leaving them at higher risk for fractures.

Parasympathetic nervous system (PSNS) "Rest and digest" branch of the autonomic nervous system; the relaxation response.

Peripheral nervous system (PNS) Includes the cranial and spinal nerves.

Physiology The study of the function of parts and systems in the body; the study of how the body works.

Postural hypotension Also called orthostatic hypotension; a sudden onset of low blood pressure caused by standing up too quickly from the floor or an inversion.

Prana Sanskrit word meaning life-force energy, vital energy, or breath, similar to the Chinese concept of qi; yogis believe you can consciously transform and move your prana.

Pranayama Sanskrit word meaning breath extension or control; breathwork.

Proprioception Type of interoception that focuses on spatial body awareness, particularly while in motion.

Randomized controlled trial (RCT) Randomization of the experimental group and control(s), which can lead to less bias; gold standard of research trials.

Sacroiliac joint Joint between the sacrum and ilium of the pelvis; allows a small amount of movement.

Samskaras According to Indian philosophy, these are imprints or impressions of our past actions.

Sanskrit The ancient Indian language in which many yoga texts were written.

Stretching When muscle fibers lengthen, often beyond resting length.

Sun salutation Series of asanas done in flowing sequence to warm up the body and focus the mind.

Superficial Closer to the surface; for instance, your skin is superficial to your muscles.

Supine Lying on your back, face up.

Sympathetic nervous system (SNS) "Fight or flight" branch of the autonomic nervous system; the stress response.

Synovial joint Most common and most mobile type of joint in the body, such as the shoulders, hips, and knees.

Tendon Connects muscle to bone; made of dense regular connective tissue proper, which has parallel collagen fibers.

Thoracic spine The 12 vertebrae of the mid-back region.

Tissues Collection of cells that come together for a similar function; the four primary tissue types are epithelial, connective, muscle, and nervous.

Vagus nerve Tenth cranial nerve (CN X), important in parasympathetic control of the heart, lungs, and digestive organs.

Vayus According to yoga philosophy, your prana flows in specific patterns called the vayus: Prana (in), Udana (into head), Vyana (into limbs), Samana (around), and Apana vayu (down and out).

Yoga therapy According to the International Association of Yoga Therapists, "Yoga therapy is the process of empowering individuals to progress toward improved health and well-being through the application of the teachings and practices of Yoga;" this developing field has educational standards that exceed those for general yoga instruction, and prepares practitioners to work safely with health conditions.